

NATIONAL PROGRAMME FOR TECHNOLOGY ENHANCED LEARNING

Launched in 2003

Achievement: 57 per cent schools in India have computers; 54 per cent have internet connections

used the internet or owned a device. Her uncle helped her set up an email account and ensured her phone was recharged. Classes began on Google Meet, and though initially overwhelming, she quickly adapted.

Despite unreliable internet, frequent power outages and the isolation of rural life, Laweibabha embraced every opportunity. Online education broadened her horizons, connecting her to experts from across India and providing resources like Khan Academy, e-Pathshala, and the National Digital Library.

Today, digital learning has helped Laweibabha envision a brighter future for herself and her family. "The career counselling sessions through online platforms have helped me understand my capabilities better," she says. "Online learning has kept us connected to the wider world by providing access to resources and knowledge far beyond our immediate surroundings." Stories like hers inspire countless others to dream beyond circumstances. ■

LAWEIBABHA KHONGMAWLOH, 19

Mawphlang, Meghalaya

pandemic, platforms like PM eVidya, Diksha and e-Pathshala ensured uninterrupted education even in remote areas.

Shahnaz Parbin, a 10th-grade student from Assam's Bowalimari village, embodies the transformative power of online education. Despite financial struggles, her father's purchase of a smartphone gave her access to free study materials and virtual classes, replacing costly tutoring and guidebooks. Shahnaz's resilience turned a simple device into a tool for overcoming rural and financial barriers.

A standout feature of online education is its asynchronous nature, allowing learners to study at their convenience. It democratises learning through resources such as the National Digital Library and SWAYAM Prabha, ensuring content accessibility. Downloadable content for areas with poor connectivity and multilingual support help bridge technological and linguistic gaps.

The collaborative potential of online education adds to its effectiveness. Discussion forums, virtual classrooms and group projects foster interaction among learners. Reports highlight improved learning through tools like online libraries, AI-driven platforms and mock tests.

Despite its promise, lack of reliable technology and internet access is a challenge. Addressing these issues requires infrastructure investments, such as community learning hubs with WiFi, computers and electricity. While these improvements are essential to maximise its potential, the existing framework has already transformed education. ■